

Incident Alert 0020. TLP Amber+Strict.		Date	Breakout Scale
Title	EU – Potential Doppelgänger coordinated inauthentic behaviour network on X in June 2024	15/07/2024	2

Summary

- From June 4th to 22nd 2024, inauthentic X-accounts published 1.236 posts matching pro-Russian interests using a similar posting pattern on X.
- The posts were then amplified in replies to third-party posts and replies.
- The pattern was found in German, French, English, Italian, Polish and Ukrainian.
- According to X data, the combined views of these posts reached over 4 Million.
- Authentic appearing replies to some of these original posts suggest a breakout to level 2.
- The posts discrediting Western governments and political parties, supporting pro-Russian parties,

Incident – When, Who did what, to say what, to whom, why?

From June 4th to 22nd 2024, 1.236 posts have been spread on X (formally Twitter), including in German (405), French (349), English (105), Italian (160), Polish (128) and Ukrainian (89). The post pattern typically consisted of a few lines of text followed by a shortened URL and an image, typically reaching a paradoxical combination of less than 10 likes, and 300 to 5.153 shares. Each involved account would only publish one such post. Batches of postings across accounts appear to have been published within seconds or minutes of each other, further indicating coordinated publication and possibly automation.

Narratives found discredited Ukraine, its support by others and the targeted countries' governments. Russia, Vladimir Putin and pro-Russian parties were mentioned favourably. Issues of current public interest appear to have been instrumentalized in the narratives, i.e. inflation or fear of terrorist attacks.

The method we employ to gather the X posts relies on having a social listening query that models the sharing pattern previously attributed to the Russian Doppelgänger's campaign by among others the [German MFA](#). The query collects tweets that received more than 300 shares but less than 100 likes and were published by authors with less than 100 followers, containing a link and either an image or a video. URLs spread in the posts appear to align with known FIKED patterns described by [Qurium](#). [DFRLab](#) also identified the pattern of Doppelgänger X accounts responding to other Twitter users' posts by quote-tweeting other Doppelgänger original posts.

Original posts would each be amplified by accounts sharing them as replies to other users' tweets or replies, resulting in share counts between 300 and 5.153.

The activity likely appears to be tied to the Russian influence campaign of Doppelgänger, as a part of the Russian efforts to decrease support for Ukraine among Western countries, support pro-Russian parties and discredit politicians and parties that oppose Russian interests.

Accounts publishing the original X posts appear to be under less scrutiny than the amplifying accounts. We observed that while the original posts often remained online over weeks, amplifier accounts tended to be suspended within days. As of July 10th, this activity appeared to be ongoing.

Narrative

Meta narrative: Cease Ukraine support, begin peace talks with Russia.

Sub-narratives: Discrediting Western governments and political parties, supporting pro-Russian parties, fearmongering of inflation, economic demise, etc.

Impact

Reach: In total, the 1.236 posts published between June 4th and 22nd achieved more than 4 Million views, according to X. Due to the unclear nature of reliability of this metric, this should be regarded as a rough estimate. Additionally, the actual amount of original posts and shares is estimated to be higher, due to posts seemingly be-

ing deleted from X and then disappearing from the social listening tool used.

Replies to the original posts suggest at least some visibility, likely resulting from the amplification step. For 1.236 original posts, 500 replies were found.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [Smear](#) - Smear EU member state governments and Ukraine.

Objective: [Cultivate Support for Ally](#): The influence operation is promoting political parties with favourable opinions of Russia.

[Acquire/Recruit Network](#): Most accounts were previously used for something unrelated.

[Post Inauthentic Social Media Comment](#): Inauthentic accounts use quote tweets to comment on other users' posts.

[Conceal Network Identity](#): The X accounts are not revealing that they are part of a larger network, posing as authentic users.

[Conduct Server Redirect](#): The posts contain redirect URLs to either direct users to operational content if they are the target audience or show them an irrelevant website.

Recommendations

- Action taken: CIB network reported to X 15/07/2024 – pending response. Reported to EU Institutions, the targeted EU member states.

- A wider investigation is being done and a public report will be released by the end of August.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
N/A	Ukraine, Elections	Link	Lea Frühwirth, CeMAS Saman Nazari, A4E Ned Mendez, Clash Digital E. Rosalie Li, InfoEpi Lab Dominik Uhlig, BIQdata.pl / Gazeta Wyborcza Yuliia Zhaha Rikard Friberg von Sydow, Södertörn University Stockholm	X posts	X